

15, The Evolution of Infrastructural Power Since the Restoration of the Bureaucratic State and Its Political Logic

Based on the preceding discourse, readers should already possess a profoundly deep understanding of the "profound mysteries" underlying the **restoration-bureaucratic system**. However, because the absolute severing of **despotic power** (专制性权力) from **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) constitutes one of the most essential defining characteristics of China's **restoration-bureaucratic** society, I am dedicating this specific subsection to emphasize it.

Regarding this phenomenon, historical academia, both domestic and foreign, achieved certain realizations decades ago—for instance, the so-called "localization of elites" (精英地方化) during the Southern Song Dynasty. Yet, just like all previous research concerning China, when scholars were meticulously examining a specific body part of the elephant, they fundamentally lacked the macro-awareness that they were, in fact, studying an entire elephant!

We must explicitly point out that over the millennium spanning from the early Tang to the late Ming, a primary mutation in Chinese politics was the relentless concentration of **despotic power** into the central government, while simultaneously delegating **infrastructural power** downward to the local grassroots! This specific evolutionary process inherently marked the maturation and perfection of the **restoration-bureaucratic system**.

As I previously mentioned when discussing Japan's political reforms modeled after the Tang Dynasty, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** from the Northern Wei to the early Tang was actually quite crude and unrefined. Rulers attempted to directly command and distribute the means of production (i.e., land) and retained glaring **feudal characteristics** (封建特征) in their military organization. Not only did this political apparatus lack any possibility of long-term execution, but it also posed a fatal threat to the **restoration-bureaucratic system** itself.

By the mid-to-late Tang, the Equitable Field System (均田制) had utterly vanished; the state no longer attempted to directly control the means of production. Militarily, the state underwent further "de-feudalization" (去封建化). This dynamic is absolutely not contradictory to "Fanzhen separatism" (藩镇割据 / warlordism), because the Fanzhen military system was intrinsically a recruited mercenary system (募兵制), where military service was structurally decoupled from land remuneration—fundamentally distinct from the Fubing (府兵 / garrison militia) of the Northern Wei and early Tang!

Transitioning from the Tang to the Song, institutionalized "office land" (职分田) essentially ceased to exist, although the Northern Song still retained welfare-oriented "granted land" (赐田). At this stage, the government's intervention in land distribution was drastically curtailed—a policy historically termed "not restraining land annexation" (不抑兼并) in China. However, this definitively did not signify a resurgence of **feudalization**! Because the Northern Song had already hyper-consolidated the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (*through means such as amplifying the imperial examinations*), even if land—as the **primary factor of production**—trended toward massive concentration again, the imperial court possessed inexhaustible countermeasures, and it was structurally impossible for the landlord class to mutate back into **feudal lords** (封建领主).

Under these circumstances, **infrastructural power** was further relegated to the local level. "School lands" (学田) emerged during the Northern Song, as did the lineage-based clan system spearheaded

by Fan Zhongyan (范仲淹), epitomized by "charitable estates" (义庄). Yet, even so, Northern Song politics is still categorized by scholars as "empire-oriented" (天下关怀型). Marital alliances among the **Scholar-official stratum** (士大夫阶层) retained a glaringly nationwide character, and their vested interests were not strictly confined to their native provinces.

By the Southern Song period, universal "office land" systems ceased to appear entirely, and **infrastructural power** shifted even further downward. To a massive extent, the **Scholar-official stratum** metamorphosed from nationwide political elites into socially rooted local elites! They inclined toward forging highly regionalized networks of power (*e.g., localized marital alliances*) and invested vastly more energy into the (public) affairs of their home regions.

During this phase, through the establishment of autonomous grassroots organizations like "community granaries" (社仓) and "charitable labor service" (义役), the delegation of **infrastructural power** under the model of "Xiangshen governing the locale" (乡绅治乡) was fundamentally realized! Grassroots justice, public works, welfare, moral indoctrination, and disaster response were almost exclusively managed by these **Xiangshen (local scholar-elites / 乡绅)**. One can perceive this glaringly from the shifting geographical distribution of intellectual schools: under Southern Song rule, nationwide academic schools were substantially replaced by hyper-regionalized schools of thought, and the geographical identity consciousness of intellectuals was aggressively amplified.

The late Ming Dynasty witnessed the absolute zenith of the severing of China's despotic power from its infrastructural power! The dominating power over rural society—even including the power of taxation—fell squarely into the hands of local elites such as the gentry and local magnates (士绅、土豪). Reflected in national-level politics, this manifested as the ubiquitous rise of factions and political societies (党社), to the point where they exerted a monumental impact on the political landscape of the entire empire!

It was precisely because of this dynamic that phenomenally bizarre paradoxes emerged: **for instance, the Chongzhen Emperor (崇祯皇帝) was effectively an "absolute autocrat who was practically a bare, isolated commander" (说一不二的光杆司令)!**

After "Entering the Pass" (入关), the Qing Empire established by the Manchus actively curbed this downward trajectory of infrastructural power in imperial China. To a massive extent, this reversal was the result of the gradually intensifying influence of the West. Because Turkey, Iran, and India also exhibited similar mutations to varying degrees during their periods of contact with the West, this constitutes a vital component of what I term **Pseudo-modernization (伪近/现代化)**.

The phenomenon of severing despotic power from infrastructural power has stubbornly persisted straight into the political reality of contemporary China!

For example, many domestic and foreign observers have acutely noted this reality: although the contemporary Chinese regime hyper-concentrates political power in Beijing—manifesting especially in the absolute despotic power over personnel appointments and dismissals—the economic power wielded by the individual provinces appears "exceptionally massive." **Naturally, this is absolutely not because our nation's rulers genuinely care about the welfare of the local populace; they are simply driving and dominating the masses utilizing the exact same mechanisms modeled by the emperors of the past!**

The aforementioned process is relatively clear. I will only address two potential doubts that might arise.

The first concerns the Chinese noun "**Zongzu**" (宗族 / **lineage or clan**). In China, this term is frequently utilized simultaneously to denote two fundamentally distinct concepts. The first type refers to lineages in economically developed regions that were exploited early on. The primary purpose of such lineages was explicitly to adapt to the **restoration-bureaucratic system**, particularly to its absolute core—the Imperial Examination system (科举制度). The lineage actively invested in its members by establishing charitable schools (义学) and meticulously arranging marital alliances, ensuring they perpetually maintained high-status representation within the bureaucratic apparatus.

The second type refers to lineages in newly developed, economically backward regions. In such areas, relying on the imperial examinations to secure stable social status was exceedingly difficult. Therefore, the primary function assumed by the lineage was *protection*. In contemporary parlance: **it artificially increased the "united front value" (统战价值) of atomized individuals!** For this type of lineage, armed brawls (械斗) triggered by land and water disputes, smuggling operations (*along with overseas emigration*), and even occasionally resisting the government constituted their daily routines! Under specific conditions—such as regional economic development, or occasionally producing a natural-born "bureaucratic politician" who secured a high-ranking position within the system—the second type of lineage could mutate into the first type.

The second issue lies in my own terminology. When I state that infrastructural power was "delegated downward" (下放), it might erroneously lead people to assume that the imperial government was actually pleased to see the *Xiangshen* (乡绅 / local gentry) command infrastructural power. This is, of course, utterly impossible! For instance, one can easily point out that the *Lijia* system (里甲制) implemented by Zhu Yuanzhang (朱元璋) in the early Ming Dynasty was explicitly designed—under the premise of partially utilizing pre-existing local social structures—to draconianly strengthen central control and cripple the infrastructural power held by local elites!

However, regardless of how profoundly unwilling the imperial court was, the downward shift of infrastructural power to the grassroots genuinely constituted the overarching trend over a millennium. This was simply because the **restoration-bureaucratic state** critically lacked the political capacity to centrally exercise infrastructural power. More importantly: **the absolute severing of these two powers was fundamentally beneficial to the very survival of the restoration-bureaucratic system itself!**

As we mentioned previously, once the bureaucratic system concentrates infrastructural power in the central government, it becomes fundamentally incapable of preventing bureaucrats at all echelons from exploiting their positions to perform "magic" and expropriate the means of production, thereby mutating into the ruling class! Because infrastructural power is inherently a *management-oriented* power, coordinating various sectors of society inevitably requires utilizing social infrastructure to dispatch people to execute tasks—a monarch cannot accomplish this alone!

For instance, during Emperor Wu's reign, the Western Han Dynasty forged a highly centralized, incredibly formidable bureaucratic system that held tight control over both despotic and infrastructural powers (*albeit skewed toward predation*). Consequently, over the lifespan of the next

dozen generations, the speed of **feudalization** actually accelerated phenomenally! The landlord class fully exploited the bureaucratic apparatus to massively expand its own power.

The exact same dynamic unfolded when Japan reformed its institutions modeled after the Tang Dynasty. The (centrally exercised) infrastructural power possessed by the Tang political system was simply too overwhelmingly strong for an **early state**. The Japanese Emperor alone could absolutely not keep the *Ritsuryō* system (律令制) running; thus, he possessed no capacity to prevent aristocrats like the Fujiwara clan (藤原氏) from mutating into massive manorial lords!

Hyper-concentrating despotic power in the center while aggressively dispersing infrastructural power to the local level not only achieved the sadistic reality where "those with power bear zero responsibility, and those with responsibility hold zero power" (有权者无责, 有责者无权), but more crucially, it constituted the ultimate survival mechanism for the bureaucratic system! However, this specific arcane knowledge is not something rulers of every nation can master proficiently. At present, it appears that only a nation like China—which has perfected the dark arts of "governing humans" (治人) to an absolute pinnacle—can truly unleash its terrifying efficacy.

The Soviet Union serves as an exceptionally spectacular counter-example. The Leninist party organization simultaneously endowed the regime with phenomenally formidable and hyper-concentrated despotic *and* infrastructural power! However, Russian rulers frequently blurred the lines between the party and the state administration ("党政不分"), or rather, under a hyper-centralized command economy, these two simply could not be separated.

The ultimate, inevitable evolution of this scenario was that the means of production—ostensibly labeled "state property"—fell squarely into the hands of a minority of party bureaucrats (Nomenklatura). **Once high-ranking bureaucrats mutated into the actual ruling class, what possible reason did they have to remain shackled by the constraints of the Soviet Communist Party Central Committee?** Under such circumstances, it was undeniably the most rational outcome for these elites to peacefully dismantle the Soviet Union and metamorphose into autocratic dictators and oligarchs of independent nations!

China's communist rulers evidently possessed vastly richer historical experience. During the Mao Zedong era, the management system and implementation methods of China's planned economy—compared to the Soviet Union—already exhibited a certain tendency toward "decentralization" (去中心化), and the infrastructural power wielded by local authorities was significantly greater.

Even so, barely a decade after the founding of the state, Mao himself sensed this latent existential threat with phenomenally abnormal, razor-sharp political intuition! He realized that although the Leninist party and its ideology massively fortified the bureaucratic system under modern conditions, **the hyper-concentration of infrastructural power—or rather, the direct state control over the means of production—would intrinsically and inevitably annihilate the dictatorship of the party!**

His terror regarding this "**capitalist restoration**" (资产阶级复辟) (*because under modern technological conditions, the most vital means of production is capital*) directly detonated the "Cultural Revolution" (文化大革命)! In a certain sense, the "Great Chaos" (大乱) successfully shattered the concentration of infrastructural power, and Mao achieved his objective. However, this was ultimately not a social state capable of stable existence.

After Deng Xiaoping (邓小平) seized power, through a series of novel domestic and foreign measures, he seamlessly resurrected the darkest tradition of China's **restoration-bureaucratic politics** under Communist rule: **Absolute despotic power was ruthlessly clawed back to the center; infrastructural power was aggressively offloaded to local authorities; the government opted to control the means of production via indirect mechanisms; and ultimately, "all power belongs to the top, while all responsibility is dumped on the bottom"** (权归于上而责归于下)!

This novel status quo in our nation received a perfectly tailored, euphemistic modifier: **"With Chinese Characteristics"** (中国特色).

Perhaps some might ask: Mao Zedong was a man profoundly versed in Chinese history, famously reputed to have read the *Zizhi Tongjian* (《资治通鉴》 / Comprehensive Mirror in Aid of Governance) seventeen times! Why, then, during his rule, did he not align himself closer to China's traditional bureaucratic politics?

I contend that, aside from his extraordinarily extreme personal temperament, and the reality that the Soviet model was only just beginning its massive expansion in the late 1940s (*meaning all communist leaders essentially lacked a comprehensive understanding of the status quo*), there is another overwhelmingly crucial reason: **The era had changed!**

The productive forces of Chinese society had, irrefutably, evolved into a historical epoch where **capital** had usurped land as the **primary factor of production**! The latent ruling class was now the bourgeoisie, not the landlord class.

As we pointed out when discussing Japanese history, the **feudal landlord class** has historically been a relatively "weak" ruling class across all of human history. They lived dispersed, possessed a hyper-localized mindset, and acted conservatively. These characteristics were absolutely dictated by the inherent nature of land itself as the primary factor of production in the feudal era. Human labor can reproduce and migrate; capital can exponentially proliferate and move instantaneously; **but land is strictly confined by fixed physical space!** It cannot run around, and developing new land is an agonizingly slow process with glaring limits.

Therefore, although the **bureaucratic state** could successfully suppress the landlord class and prevent it from ruling for thirteen centuries, figuring out how to violently suppress the bourgeoisie was undeniably an entirely novel problem for China's bureaucratic politicians! It was perfectly normal that they required time to grope in the dark. Furthermore, China was undergoing a ferocious industrialization process, making the rapid proliferation of capital virtually inevitable. This undeniably exacerbated the existential dread of the bureaucratic rulers.

Many policies during the Mao era genuinely reflected this deliberate calculus of strictly preventing the ruling class from actually seizing rule—most classically epitomized by the draconian restrictions on population mobility between urban and rural areas, and the violent expulsion of intellectuals to the countryside (上山下乡). By the late 1970s, China's **bureaucratic state** had acquired an increasingly profound understanding of the capitalist world. Concurrently, rapid shifts in the international geopolitical landscape became vastly more conducive to "restoring the old system" (恢复旧制). This laid the absolute foundation for China's **restoration-bureaucratic system** to enter a novel epoch, fundamentally predicated on the suppression of the bourgeoisie!

Today, people have already witnessed that this specific reform—regardless of what it meant for the ordinary Chinese populace—was spectacularly effective for China's rulers and the ruling party! Our nation's political apparatus has maintained fundamental stability for nearly half a century, utterly surviving the apocalyptic shockwaves that annihilated the Soviet Union and the socialist states of Eastern Europe.

This undeniably appears phenomenally bizarre. After all, Mao Zedong and Deng Xiaoping are routinely perceived, both domestically and internationally, as possessing vastly divergent political stances; the Cultural Revolution and the "Reform and Opening Up" (改革开放) are frequently viewed as diametrically opposed polarities. **Yet, the terrifying historical reality is that the ultimate objective these two generations of leaders sought to achieve was absolutely identical!** Namely: to fiercely preserve China's **restoration-bureaucratic system** under the premises of modern technological conditions and the dictatorship of a Leninist party—and ultimately, this objective was successfully realized!

People should take this as a dire warning, constantly reminding themselves of the terrifying deceptiveness and mind-bending complexity of Chinese history. Individuals who appear aligned may execute diametrically opposed actions; individuals who appear utterly incompatible may actually be operating for the exact same ultimate objective! For outsiders, distinguishing truth from illusion, reality from falsehood, is phenomenally excruciating. Especially for foreigners who do not live in China, attempting to comprehend China's history and reality without the assistance of a "native guide" is exactly like plunging into a colossal, labyrinthine underground cave system without prior reconnaissance, technical equipment, or logistical backup—avoiding disorientation and mortal peril is virtually impossible!

Our nation's history is agonizingly protracted, its documentary sources are hyper-abundant yet infested with sycophantic fabrications (佞史极多), and its social structure is uniquely convoluted. **Due to the perpetual existence of the restoration-bureaucratic government, the historical narrative has been artificially and systematically distorted for millennia!**

Even for those living within China's borders, it is critically imperative to constantly distinguish between two fundamental societal characteristics—**infrastructural power** and **despotic power**—as well as the personal psychological traits of rulers, such as tolerance or sheer sadism. While these three elements are undeniably interlinked, they possess relative independence. Societal characteristics cannot be magically altered by any single individual, and a person's individual personality might violently clash with the structural commonalities of society!

For instance, when the scholars of the Tang Dynasty evaluated the reign of Emperor Wenxuan of Northern Qi, Gao Yang (北齐文宣皇帝高洋), they encapsulated it in eight characters: "*The monarch is deranged above, yet the administration is immaculate below*" ("主昏于上，政清于下"). This can be considered a phenomenally accurate empirical observation.

Naturally, we can now flawlessly explain this phenomenon using sociological theory: The Northern Qi regime was one of the major regimes in Chinese history with the highest degree of **feudalization**! Both the **infrastructural power** and **despotic power** possessed by the emperor and the imperial court were agonizingly weak. The Han aristocratic great clans (汉族世家) and Xianbei military aristocracies (鲜卑军事贵族) independently shouldered massive burdens of social governance at the local level. The despotic power Gao Yang could actually wield was phenomenally

limited; otherwise, how could the emperor be utterly powerless to prevent his own brother from murdering his son?

When both infrastructural and despotic powers are abysmally weak, the ruler's personal psychological profile has an exceedingly limited impact on the entire society! Therefore, even if Gao Yang himself was a sadistic, deranged lunatic, it was structurally exceptionally difficult for him to inflict instantaneous, catastrophic consequences upon the whole of society!

However, the logic we perceive today completely contradicts the understanding of the Tang scholars back then! The Tang scholars genuinely believed this favorable situation was entirely attributable to highly trained bureaucrats and a flawlessly operating bureaucratic system. **This is the exact opposite of the truth!** If the Northern Qi's bureaucrats were genuinely highly trained, and its bureaucratic system was undeniably robust and formidable, then the inevitable consequence of "*a deranged monarch above*" would absolutely be "*an apocalyptic socio-political collapse below*" ("政糜于下")!

Ancient Chinese scholars possessed virtually zero knowledge of the social sciences. Coupled with the deliberate, systematic deception perpetrated by bureaucratic ideology, even political treatises universally highly revered in Chinese history—such as the *Zhenguan Zhengyao* (《贞观政要》/ Essentials of Governance of the Zhenguan Period)—frequently contain judgments that are simply grotesque and unreadable by modern standards.

This is precisely why I assert that the greatest agony in researching our nation's history is not that "a few specific areas require correcting chaos and restoring truth" (拨乱反正); rather, the terrifying reality is asking: exactly how few areas are left that DO NOT require correcting chaos and restoring truth?!

15, 官僚国家复辟以来基础性权力的变化及其政治逻辑

读者根据之前所述, 应该已经对于复辟官僚制度的“奥妙”有了相当深入的认识, 不过因为专制性权力和基础性权力相分离构成了中国复辟官僚社会的本质特征之一, 因此我在这里单独用一个小节强调一下。有关这一点, 国内外的历史学界早在几十年前就已经有所认识, 例如所谓南宋时期的“精英地方化”。但是就如同过往所有有关中国的研究一样, 学者们在研究大象某一部位时, 并不知道自己正在研究一头大象。

我们应当指出的是, 从初唐到晚明一千年间, 中国政治的一个主要变化就是不断把专制性权力集中到中央的同时, 下放基础性权力到地方。这个过程本身标志着复辟官僚体制的成熟和完善。我之前在谈到日本仿照唐朝进行政治改革的时候就已经提到过, 从北魏到初唐时期的复辟官僚体制是相当潦草的, 统治者试图直接掌握生产资料(即土地)并分配它, 在军事上也保留有明显的封建特征。这种政治体制不但没有长期执行的可能性, 而且也会对复辟官僚体制造成威胁。到中晚唐的时候, 均田制就已经消失了, 现在国家不再试图直接控制生产资料。军事上进一步去封建化, 这一点跟藩镇割据完全不矛盾, 因为藩镇兵制在本质上也是募兵制, 军事服役和土地报酬是脱钩的, 与北魏到初唐的府兵完全不同了。

由唐入宋, 制度化的职分田已经不存在了, 不过北宋还保留有福利性质的赐田。到这个阶段, 政府对于土地分配的干预大为减少, 在中国历史上被称为“不抑兼并”, 但是它并不意味着封建化的重新抬头。因为北宋已经通过(增强科举等方式)巩固了复辟官僚体制, 土地作为首位生产资料再有集中的趋势, 朝廷总有应对的手段, 地主阶级也不可能再向封建领主转化。在这种情况下, 基础性权力进一步下放到地方, 学田制度出现在北宋, 范仲淹摸索出的以“义庄”为代表的宗族制度也出现在北宋。但是即使如此, 北宋政治在学者们看来依然是“天下关怀型”的, 士大夫之间的联姻具有明显的全国性, 其利益也不局限在籍贯地。

到南宋时期, 普遍的职田制度已经不再出现, 基础性权力进一步下移。士大夫在一定程度上从全国性的政治精英向扎根地方的社会精英转变, 他们倾向于结成地域性的权力网络(例如本地联姻), 把更

多精力投入到家乡（公共）事务中。在这一阶段，通过“社仓”“义役”这样的自治组织，“乡绅治乡”模式的基础性权力下放就基本实现，基层司法、公共工程、福利、道德教化、灾难应对等等事业基本上都由乡绅来操办。人们从学派地域分布的变化就很明显地能看出这一点，南宋统治下，全国性的学派一定程度上被区域性的学派所取代，知识分子的地域身份意识增强。

晚明时期见证了中国专制性权力和基础性权力分离的巅峰，乡村社会的支配权力，甚至包括税收的权力，落到了士绅、土豪这样的地方精英手中。反映到国家层面的政治上就是党社的普遍崛起，以致对于整个帝国的政局产生显著影响。正因如此，才会出现一些非常奇怪的现象，比如说崇祯皇帝就是一个“说一不二的光杆司令”。满洲人入关之后建立的清帝国遏制了帝制中国基础性权力的下移过程，这在很大程度上是西方影响逐渐增强的结果。因为土耳其、伊朗和印度在同西方接触的时期或多或少也出现了类似变化，也就是我所说的“伪近代化”的一部分。

政治中专制性权力和基础性权力分离的现象一直延续到现如今的中国政治中。例如很多国内外的观察者都很清楚的观察到了这样一点：现如今的中国政权虽然在政治权力上高度集中于北京，这尤其体现在人事任免权上；但是各个省的经济权力看起来“非常之大”。这当然不是因为我国统治者真的在关心地方百姓的福祉，他们正是如此仿照过去的皇帝一般驾驭万民。

以上过程是比较清楚的，我只解释两个可能出现的疑问。第一个就是汉语名词“宗族”，这个词在中国经常被同时用来表示两种存在差异的概念。一种是指开发时间较早的经济发达地区的宗族，这种宗族存在的主要目的就是适应复辟官僚制度，尤其是作为重中之重的科举制度。宗族通过兴办义学，谨慎联姻等方式对于族人进行投资，确保自己始终在官僚系统内具有足够地位的代表。另一种是指新开发的，经济落后地区的宗族，在这种地方想要指望通过科举获得稳定的社会地位很难。因此宗族主要承担的功能就是庇护，按现在的话说，就是为原子化的个体增加了统战价值。像土地和水源纠纷引起的械斗，走私活动（以及海外移民）甚至一定程度上对抗官府才是这种宗族的日常行为。在一定条件下，比如经济发展或者说偶然出了一个天生的“官僚主义政客”在体制内取得高位，第二种宗族会向第一种宗族转化。

第二个问题在我自己的用词上，当我说基础性权力“下放”的时候很可能让人误以为帝国政府对于乡绅掌握基础性权力喜闻乐见，这当然不可能。就好比人们可以很容易指出明初朱元璋所推行的里长制就是在一定程度利用地方原有的社会结构的前提下，加强对地方的控制，削弱了地方精英拥有的基础性权力。只不过朝廷再怎么不愿意，基础性权力向基层转移在一千年的时间里确实是总体趋势，因为复辟官僚国家缺少集中使用基础性权力的政治能力。更重要的是，两种权力的分置对于复辟官僚制度本身存在好处。

我们在之前就已经提到，官僚制度一旦将基础性权力集中到中央，那么它将无法阻止各级官僚利用职务之便各显神通攫取生产资料，进而向统治阶级转变。因为基础性权力毕竟是一种管理型的权力，要协调社会各个领域总得通过社会基础设施让人去办事，君主一个人是做不到的。例如汉武帝时期西汉形成了一套虽然偏向于掠夺性的，但是专制性权力和基础性权力都高度集中并且强力的官僚制度，那么在接下来十几代人的时间里，封建化的速度实际上是加快了，因为地主阶级充分利用了官僚体制来扩张自己的力量。日本在仿照唐朝的制度进行改革的时候也是如此，唐代政治体制所拥有的（中央行使的）基础性权力相对于一个早期国家来说太强了，天皇一个人不可能让律令制运转起来，那么他就没办法阻止藤原氏这样的贵族像大庄园主转变。把专制性权力高度集中到中央，基础性权力分散到地方，不仅仅是实现了“有权者无责，有责者无权”，更是官僚体制赖以生存的要领。然而，这个知识不是每个国家的统治者都能够熟练掌握的，目前看来也只有像中国这样对于“治人”手段运用到炉火纯青的国家才能发挥其威力。

苏联就是一个非常好的例子，列宁式的政党组织同时赋予了这个政权强大且集中的专制性权力和基础性权力，但是俄国统治者往往“党政不分”，或者说在高度集中的指令性计划经济下也分不开。这种情况演变的最终结果是，作为所谓“国家财产”的生产资料落入到了少数党官僚手中，一旦高级官僚向统治阶级转变，它凭什么还要受到一个苏共中央的掣肘呢？在这种情况下，大家通过和平方式把苏联解体掉，各自转变为独立国家的独裁统治者和寡头显然是最合理的。中国的共产主义统治者显然更有历史经验，在毛泽东时代，中国计划经济的管理体制和实施方式相对于苏联都有一定“去中心化”的倾向，地方的基础性权力是更大的。

即使如此，在开国十几年之后毛本人还是以异乎寻常的敏锐察觉到了这种潜在威胁，即列宁式政党及其意识形态虽然在现代条件下增强了官僚体制，但是它对于基础性权力高度集中或者说对于生产资料

的直接控制本身就会毁灭党的专政。这种对于“资产阶级复辟”（因为现代技术条件下最重要的生产资料是资本）担忧的一个直接结果就是“文化大革命”的发动。从某种意义上说，“大乱”确实破坏了基础性权力的集中，毛的目的达到了，但是这终究不是一种能够稳定存在的社会状态。在邓小平掌握权力之后，他通过一系列对内和对外的新措施在共产党统治下恢复了中国复辟官僚政治的传统：专制性权力收归中央，基础性权力下放地方，政府主要通过间接的方式掌握生产资料，权归于上而责归于下。这种新的状态在我国得到了一个恰如其分的修饰词，那就是“中国特色”。

或许有人会问，毛泽东本身是一个熟知中国历史的人，在中国素来有读了十七遍《资治通鉴》的名声，为什么他执政的时候不向中国的传统官僚政治靠拢呢？我认为除了他本人比较极端的个性，以及苏联模式在40年代后期也仅仅是刚刚大幅扩张（因此各共产国家领袖本质上对于现状缺少认识）这两个因素以外，还有一个非常重要的缘由是，时代已经变了。中国社会的生产力水平无论如何都已经发展到了一个资本取代土地成为首位生产资料的历史时期，现在潜在的统治阶级是资产阶级而非地主阶级。我们在之前谈论日本历史的时候就已经指出，封建地主阶级在整个人类历史上是一个相对“弱势”的统治阶级，他们居住分散，地域性强，行事相对保守。这些特点都是由作为封建时代的首位生产要素土地本身的特征决定的，作为劳动力的人可以繁殖并且迁徙，资本可以快速增殖并且移动，但是土地被非常固定的空间所限制，它既不能到处乱跑，开发新地也是一个缓慢的过程并且有明显的极限。因此官僚国家虽然可以在十三个世纪里压制地主阶级避免其进行统治，但是如何打击资产阶级对于中国的官僚主义政客来说的确是新问题，需要时间摸索是正常的。更何况中国正在进行剧烈的工业化进程，资本的快速增殖又难以避免，这确实加重了官僚统治者的忧虑。毛时代的很多政策确实都体现出严防统治阶级取得统治的考量，尤以严格限制城乡之间的人口流动，将知识分子驱逐至农村为典型。到70年代末，中国的官僚国家已经对于一个资本主义的世界越来越了解，同时国际局势的迅速变化对于“恢复旧制”更为有利，这就为中国复辟官僚制度进入一个以压制资产阶级为主要目的的新时期奠定了基础。

现在人们已经看到，这种改革不说对于中国老百姓如何，至少对于中国的统治者和执政党来说是非常有效的，我国的政治体制已经维持了近半个世纪的基本稳定，没有被苏联和东欧社会主义国家崩溃的冲击波摧毁。这一点看起来的确非常怪异，毕竟毛泽东和邓小平两个人在政治立场上往往被视为具有很大差异，文化大革命和改革开放在国内外经常被视为相互对立的举措。然而事实就是，这两代领导人所要实现的目的确实是一致的，即在现代技术条件和列宁式政党专政的前提下维护中国的复辟官僚体制，并且最终这个目的被实现了。人们应当以此为戒时常提醒自己牢记中国历史的欺骗性和复杂性，看起来一致的人采取的行动截然相反，看起来不相为谋的人实际上出于一个目的行事，其中虚实真假旁人极为难辨。特别是对于不在中国生活的外国人来说，试图在没有“本地人”协助的情况下了解中国的历史和现实这件事情就如同在没有提前考察，技术装备和后援的支持下进入一个庞大的地下洞穴系统，不陷入迷惑和危险的处境是很难的。

我国的历史漫长，文献资料丰富但佞史极多，社会结构独特且复杂。由于复辟官僚政府的存在，历史叙事长期被人为扭曲。即使对于在中国境内生活的人来说，时刻区分专制性权力和基础性权力这两种社会特征以及宽容或残暴这种统治者个性上的特点是很重要的。这三者之间的确有联系，但是具有相对独立性，社会特征不是由任何个人能够改变的，人的个性跟社会的共性可能差异很大。例如唐人在评价北齐文宣帝高洋的执政时，以“主昏于上，政清于下”八字概括，这就可以说是非常精准了。我们现在当然可以用社会学理论解释这种现象。北齐政权是中国历史上封建化程度最高的主要政权之一，皇帝以及朝廷所拥有的基础性权力是很弱的，汉族世家和鲜卑军事贵族在地方承担了很多社会治理的任务。北齐皇帝能掌握的专制性权力也有限，不然皇帝怎么会全然无法阻止弟弟杀死自己的儿子呢？在两种权力都很弱的情况下，统治者个人的性格对于整个社会影响就极为有限了，所以高洋自己残暴归残暴，也很难对全社会造成立竿见影的恶果。然而，我们今天所看到的逻辑和唐人当年的认识并不一样，唐朝人认为这种局面归功于训练有素的官僚和运行良好的官僚制度。这与事实截然相反，如果北齐的官僚果真训练有素，官僚制度的确强而有力的话，那么“主昏于上”的结果就必然是“政糜于下”了。古代中国人对于社会科学几近一无所知，再加上官僚主义意识形态有意的误导，即使如《贞观政要》这般在中国历史上评价颇高的政论书，其论断也往往不堪入目。这也就是为什么我说我国历史研究最大的困难不是有几个地方需要拨乱反正的事，而是究竟还剩几处不需要拨乱反正的问题。